The White Rose: Sophie Scholl 1921-1943

By Erika Mumford

It is the deep, green and dark forest
where the wild animals spring past
Snow White. Pine cones dot the moss,
and mushrooms, small one-legged people,
stand straight and silent in their scarlet hoods.

Why is Father sad?

"There was once a splendid castle
filled with treasure: carpets
from Isfahan, ruby and cobalt goblets,
rock crystal windows, floors of ebony,
and fountains everywhere. You would have thought
the people who lived there
the luckiest in the world.

But in the cellar of that castle
a frightful slaughter went on day and night
until blood bubbled up from the ground
and dyed the fountains red."

"But Papa," says Hans "are you sure,

4NG Fanatics

are you sure the Fuehrer knows
about the camps?"

Some people believe
this is the end of the world.

INTRODUCTION

Hans and Sophie Scholl were German teenagers in the 1930s. Like other young Germans, they enthusiastically joined the Hitler Youth. Initially they like thousands of others believed that Adolf Hitler was leading the German people back to greatness. Their parents were not so enthusiastic. Gradually, Hans and Sophie came to realize that their parents were right: Hitler and the Nazis were enslaving and destroying the German people. The government had become an evil regime, sending hundreds of thousands of its citizens to their deaths.

This is the story Sophie Scholl's resistance. This is the story of The White Rose. It is a lesson in dissent. It is a tale of courage, of principle, of honor. The White Rose: Sophie Scholl 1921-1943 by Erika Mumford.

"Drink your cocoa, Sophie,
you've hardly touched your breakfast."

"Too much to do - the rally this afternoon -
is my blouse ready?"

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

"And your piano lesson?"

Piano lesson!

"But Mama, the Fuehrer himself is speaking -
you know our troop has to be there.
Don't you want to come?"

She slams the iron down.

"Here - take it - go!"
And then her arms are around me.
"The Pied Piper - remember?"

"Oh Mama - that dumb story - "

****

They're calling it *Kristallnacht* - lovely word
that makes you think of jewelled chandeliers'
blaze in a midnight-blue and silver ballroom
where waltzing couples whirl, and violins
set all the drops of moonlight trembling.
Night
of smashed and trampled lives,
the image in the mirror crazed and blinded
beyond repair. Oh delicate splinters, stars

4NG Fanatics

sparkling like tears on the soiled face of earth,
oh piercing, bloody fragments: Crystal.
Night

****

- the sound we wait for. Wail
rising and falling in my sleep shocked
torn awake stumble
into clothes
I grab Inge's hand *quick hurry*
Father at the cellar door
"It's all right - don't rush
Werner, here's the thermos. Hans
your coat" rising, falling
"Where's Mother" - "here, Sophie
take this blanket". CRASH and
CRASH not this house not us
walls tremble, tinkle of glass CRASH fainter
this time thank God further silence
the All Clear.

****

"Beloved, let us pray
also for Yakov Androvenko,
forced-laborer in this parish

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

who was beaten to death - "

in the night, Herr Pastor Harms
is arrested
- but our whole country is a prison.

A friend of Hans's returned from the front
to find his wife - an epileptic,
pregnant with their first child -
gassed.

Today in a shuffling, close-packed column
of old men, women, young girls and boys
all wearing yellow stars
all carrying suitcases,
I saw a baby playing peek-a-boo
over his mother's shoulder. His laughter
spurted into the smoky air
like jets of blood.

****

Munich seems vast to me
coming from little Ulm. And everywhere the grisly
bombed buildings, gaping like smashed dollhouses
- you can see where stairs went up, tatters
of flowered wallpaper, a picture hanging crazily

4NG Fanatics

above charred heaps that once were chairs.

Strange, how in the midst of this
we can still laugh together,
still celebrate.

my first day
at the University -
Hans and his friends gave a party for me.

Later we talked. And Hans: "It sickens me -
the irony of medical school, healing people
for Hitler to feed into this roaring furnace
of war - and into those - into those other ovens . . .
I can't remember who first spoke the word
resistance. Then Christoph -
"How can we hold our heads up ever again,
a nation of cowards ruled by criminals?"
What if we win this war? Already
they are warning us
that rather than hang around the universities
we should be "making a child for Hitler".
My flesh creeps - I want to plunge into my studies
as into a cleansing stream.

****

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

In large, clear letters on the blackboard
Professor Huber's text from Lao Tzu:

Do you think you can take over the universe
and improve it?
If you try to hold it you will lose it.

If you rejoice in victory
you delight in killing.
Force is followed by loss of strength.

That which goes against the Tao
comes to an early end.

The mild words are an open dare.
If just one student should denounce him?
Watching him balance on that knife-edge
I draw deep breaths of icy mountain air.

****

Leaflets on floors and windowsills
- with pounding heart I read
Nothing is so unworthy of a civilized nation
as that it should permit itself to be governed
by an irresponsible ruling caste
that has surrendered

4NG Fanatics

to its darkest instincts . . .
resist . . . a people deserves that government
it tolerates . . . resist . . .

We're not alone, then -
there are others like us!
In the main lecture hall
women with pails and brushes
are scrubbing slogans off the walls:
DOWN WITH HITLER!
FREEDOM!

Goosebumps along my arms
- it's in the air,
spark of resistance - flame - fire –

In classes, whispering excitement.
Impossible to keep my mind
on philosophy today.
I rush to Hans's room
- he'll have spent the morning at the lab
and won't have seen the flyers.

A book lies open on his desk,
a sentence, lightly underlined
leaps out: *A people deserves*
that government it tolerates.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

O merciful God.

****

Why must it be me?
Why not you?
But there are others, political people -
The work is not political.
people who understand this kind of thing -
What don't you understand?
organizations -
We are born and die alone.
I don't want to die.
The work is urgent.
Oh please, please don't
The decision is yours.
I'm so afraid.
Yes.

****

Breathless, in the streetcar. Beside me
an S.S. officer fidgets, glances restlessly
about. Once, horribly,
I catch his eye. My briefcase
burns into my side, I can't stop

4NG Fanatics

seeing the clasp give way, papers
spilling, whirling into people's laps -
does it look odd? Too full?
Should I have looked away so quickly?

The ticket collector -
breathe deeply - don't run - I fumble
with change - the briefcase
slips, crashes down, the officer
grabs it his face swims before my eyes
- hands it back, smiling -
hot trickle of terror down my leg

There are times at night
when I am fear, icy, my bones
liquid, blood humming in darkness
listening. I pray to sleep, I pray
to wake and find myself and Hans,
Christoph and Alex and the others
just students again.
The deadly pressure lifted.

****

It is morning, the University
about to open. In the stillness
before voices, the slam and clatter

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

of doors, our footsteps
sound like shots. Hans and I
lean over the topmost bannister, empty
our bags. **A** snowfall of paper
settles on landings, stairs.
Relief,
familiar, welling nausea.
I grasp the railing
to keep my legs from giving way.
Hans hugs me, our eyes meet. His
are glowing. "Let's get out of here."

We take the stairs two at a time,
reach the door, which
and time slows
stops won't open impossible
won't
open
I'm still trying
to grasp why is the janitor sirens
"Hans! The police"
uniformed men surround us

so quickly done

****

4NG Fanatics

Stripped naked, my chain with the gold cross
broken, clothes
turned inside out, seams slit, flesh
shrinking from hard fingers
when very quietly,
"if you have anything forbidden on you
destroy it now. I'm a prisoner too."
The clothes she gives me hang on me
as though already
my body takes up less space.

****

An entire day and night
of questioning

The officers who question me
seem puzzled.
I was even offered coffee.
"If you had realized, Fraulein Scholl,
how you have undermined the war effort,
surely you would have acted differently?"

Christoph, Herr Huber, Willi, Alex - my mind
shuts around you - not one crack of light
- silence
the room

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

tilts

****

The indictment - so thick
the list of all my crimes?

In spite of myself
my hands
shake
I can hardly hold it
much less read
the type that
blurs
and
chatters on the page.
I force myself
to look
to ***look***

until the words stand
clear
black and implacable:
High Treason.

will it hurt to die

4NG Fanatics

****

Judge Freisler himself
was flown here for our trial.
Blood-red robes, cold heavy-lidded eyes
- so everything has been decided.

Hans. After these dark days and nights - your smile,
warm
sunshine. Christoph's blue, blue eyes.
Out there, a blur - so many people?
Mother and Father, I am willing you
to come dear God to come in time

"Traitors, sniveling trash - "
Freisler actually foams at the mouth, rage
shakes him like a terrier a rat

it has nothing to do with me.

Silence - a question -
I shake my head, no. Hans
is saying something

Freisler's mouth
a black hole dribbling . . . *treason*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

To be beheaded. Beheaded.
Beheaded.

****

A still and luminous room.
Mother and Father - it is only air
that parts us, not this silly barrier.
I hardly feel the floor beneath my feet.

- We've brought - they let us bring -
this chocolate - Hans
didn't want any –

- Will they arrest you, too?

- We're in God's hands
as you are, Sophie –
I've never seen you
so beautiful - but you're trembling –

- I'm not afraid.
Mama? I promise
I'm not afraid.

****

4NG Fanatics

Some people believe
this is the end of the world.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Erika Mumford
Book: Willow Water
ISBN: 978-0961996017
Publisher: Every Other Thursday Press
Date (Month/Year): May 1988

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY